MS-203 – Microsoft 365 Messaging Trainer Preparation Guide

July 2020

Design of the Courses

The Microsoft 365 Messaging course is actually a conglomeration of the three MS-200.x courses and the two MS-201.x courses. Those courses were each basically 1-1 ½ day courses, and we combined them all together into this one, 5-day course.

This course is designed for IT Professionals who deploy and manage the messaging infrastructure for Microsoft 365 in their organization, as well as those individuals who aspire to the Microsoft 365 Messaging Administrator role. Students should have a proficient understanding of DNS and basic functional experience with Microsoft 365 services, as well as a proficient understanding of general IT practices.

Required Materials to Teach This Course

To teach this course, you need the following materials:

- Microsoft PowerPoint files
- Student manual that includes additional reading links
- Lab environment provided by your lab hosting provider. The lab instructions are provided in the lab environment.
- Paper-based exercise in Module 11. Students will be provided a link to the file used in this exercise within their student manual.
- Lab solution guide for the Final Assessment lab in Module 12 (Lab 10, Exercise 3). Students will be provided a link to the pdf file that provides the step-by-step lab instructions for this exercise within their student manual.

Prerequisite Knowledge to Teach This Course

To successfully teach this course, instructors must have a working knowledge of Microsoft 365 workloads, and they should have prior experience in the Microsoft 365 Messaging Administrator role.

Instructors should also have a working knowledge of networking, server administration, and IT fundamentals, such as DNS, Active Directory, and PowerShell.

Preparation Tasks

Instructors should complete the following tasks to prepare for this course:

- Review all topics in the student manual. You should be well-versed in every topic.
- Review all PowerPoint slides.
    - Be able to speak to each of the talking points on the slides. Some slides simply provide a graphic from the associated topic. These are provided so that you can speak to the graphic and use it to help explain the key talking points in the topic.
    - The key items on each slide should NOT be read verbatim to the students. The students can read the slides themselves. Rather, the points on each slide reflect the key information that you should focus on when discussing each topic. You should use your experience as a subject matter expert to explain the What, the Why, and the How of each topic. This is your opportunity to provide a real value-add above and beyond the highlighted talking points.
- Review the Additional Reading links provided in the student manual. It is recommended that you present key points from this material to the students as the value-add that you provide as an instructor.
- Specific demonstrations are not called out in the student manual. However, as you prepare for the class, you should review each topic and determine which ones you want to perform demonstrations of the corresponding product functionality. It is up to you to decide which product features you want to demonstrate to the class, and you should use your experience to identify key points during the demonstration process. This is an area where you should rely on your experience as a subject matter expert to provide additional value-add to the students.
- You should review the questions in the Module Review activity at the end of each module so that you know why the correct answer(s) is correct for each question. Students may challenge some of the questions, so you need to be able to address any of those concerns.
- You should perform the labs yourself prior to class so that you become familiar with them and with any of the difficult points in the lab exercises. This will prepare you for helping students in case they get stuck.

Course Timing

Course timing is built around three aspects of course material – lecture, labs, discussions, and module review questions (optional).

Lecture

While these courses have not been put through a beta test to determine the exact timing of each module, it is estimated that instructors should be able to complete two to three modules per day, not counting labs and discussions. However, module 12 may prove to be the exception. There are 3 lab exercises in this module, so this module may be an all-day event.

Labs

As you perform each lab in preparation for the course, it is strongly suggested that you track your time to complete each lab. This will enable you to determine the timing of your course agenda for each day.

Module 11 does not have a hands-on lab, but it does have a paper-based lab exercise. Students will click on the link in their student manual to download the file used in the exercise. You should allow at least 20 minutes for students to complete the exercise, during which they answer the questions in the document.

Each student should then partner up with another student to review their solutions.

- For courses taught within a classroom, each student should physically partner up with another student to review each of their two solutions.
- For virtual classes, each student can be partnered with another student and email their files to one another. Students may have to disconnect from the virtual course and phone their partners to discuss their solutions over the phone before rejoining the class call.

You should allow around 20 minutes for student discussion with their partner. Once they have finished with the partner discussion, you should then have a class discussion on each of the questions, which should take another 20 minutes. So all in all, you should allot an hour for this exercise as you plan your agenda.

Module 12 includes a new Final Assessment lab that was not part of the original MS-200/201 courses. This lab asks the students to troubleshoot a message delivery problem within their newly installed Adatum hybrid Exchange deployment using the information they have learned throughout the course. A step-by-step solution guide is available for students to download in the event they are unable to solve the problem on their own. You should allot students at least an hour to complete this exercise. If they are unable to solve the problem within the first 45 minutes, they should probably turn to the lab solution for assistance.

Discussions

For the Module Review discussion questions at the end of each module, you should allow around 10 to 15 minutes to discuss key takeaways from the module and how they plan to implement the module feature in their organizations.

Module review questions (optional)

If you provide students with time to review the module assessment questions at the end of each module, you should provide at least 30 minutes per module to complete the questions for that module, along with an additional 15 minutes per module to respond to student questions or challenges concerning certain questions they may not understand or whose answers they disagree with (so 45 minutes total, although this may increase to 60 minutes if students need more than 30 minutes to get through a module questions). See the section below on Module Review Questions for further recommendations concerning those assessment questions.

Labs

The labs must be completed within the lab environment provided by your lab hosting provider. Detailed, step-by-step instructions are provided for each lab and presented as part of the UI experience within your lab environment.

At the time the courses were released, the lab instruction had been thoroughly tested and the lab steps were 100% accurate. However, given the cloud nature of Microsoft 365 and the fact that Microsoft releases UI updates on a fairly regular basis, it is possible that at some point in time, the UI for a given feature may change so that it no longer matches the lab instruction.

The Module 0 (Course introduction) slide deck has a slide that covers this warning, along with a notation that if students encounter lab steps that do not accurately reflect a UI, they will have to simply work through the UI to determine what they need to do. Typically, UI changes are quite subtle, so hopefully you do not find yourself in a situation where a feature was completely overhauled.

However, if you do run into major UI changes, challenge your students to work through it, and only offer help if they cannot figure it out themselves. Product UI changes will be part of their life in Microsoft 365. As IT/Pros, they need to learn how to work through such situations.

One thing we do ask of you is that if you run into situations such as this where lab instructions no longer match the corresponding UI, please document the issue, contact Microsoft Support, and then send them your notes. This will help the World-Wide Learning team update the course content to keep it as up-to-date as possible.

NOTE: Since the Security Admin Center and the Compliance Admin Center are still in preview mode and redirect you back to the SCC for most services, we decided to use the SCC source destination rather than call out the specific individual Admin centers.

Paper-based Exercise in Module 11

As mentioned earlier, Module 11 does not have a hands-on lab, but it does have a paper-based lab exercise. Students will click on the link in their student manual to download the file used in the exercise. A similar copy of that document is available in the MCT Download folder, along with this Trainer Prep Guide and the Course Change Log. The Trainer Guide for this paper-based lab exercise differs from the student version in that it provides suggested answers to each of the questions the students must answer. When you get to the final step in the lab, which is discussing with the students answers to each question, you should use this Trainer Guide version to help with the discussion. If students do not mention any of the

suggested answers, you can mention them to the class as additional considerations. This provides you with information you can offer as a value-add component in your role as the instructor.

Hybrid Lab Exercises

The final four lab exercises in the course all deal with preparing for and installing a hybrid Exchange deployment. This starts with Lab 9 in Module 10 and continues with the three exercises in Lab 10 in Module 12. These labs are fairly complicated, and if you have had any experience in installing a hybrid deployment, you know that it can be pretty finicky, even under the best of circumstances. In our VM lab environment, students may experience some quirky behavior, so be prepared to help them along.

As such, the lab instructions are bit more verbose in these lab exercises than normal. We have tried to provide as much guidance as possible given the situations we encountered while creating and testing the labs. It is essential that students take their time and do not rush through the labs steps. Since these final four lab exercises all build upon one another, it is essential that they successfully complete each one so that they can progress through the labs.

Remind them to carefully read through all the instructions and not assume they can just click, click, click to get through the steps. As the old saying goes, “this is a marathon and not a sprint”. No points are handed out for finishing first. One missed step or one incorrectly configured step can make all the difference between success and failure.

There is one area in particular that we want to call out for your attention. In Module 10, Lab 9, they add a custom domain and then configure it in preparation for the hybrid deployment labs in Module 12. In two of the tasks in Lab 9, they must configure the domain using PowerShell commands. There are 13 commands that must be run between the two tasks, and many of the commands are quite lengthy. To facilitate this process, the lab instructions direct the students to copy the steps from each task into Notepad, do a mass replace on the custom domain name and UPN name, and then copy the commands from Notepad and paste them into PowerShell. This will save students from having to manually type in each command into PowerShell.

One note about the copy and paste process (this is mentioned in the instructions, but it’s worth repeating here). The easiest way to do this is to simply copy all the steps they will use – this includes all the verbiage in the steps as well as the PowerShell commands themselves. This will be faster than copying just the PowerShell commands. For example, one task has 11 commands. They can do 1 copy of all 11 steps (along with all the additional instruction) as opposed to copying just the commands, which would take 11 copies. So Notepad will contain all the step-by-step instruction along with the commands, but they will obviously copy just the commands from Notepad as they progress through the commands to run them. They will have to flip between Notepad and Powershell to run each command, but this will be the safest and most expedient way to get through all the commands. Using Notepad in this manner to copy and paste in commands will hopefully alleviate any typographical errors that students often times experience when typing in PowerShell commands, especially with the lengthier commands.

Final Assessment lab

In Module 12, a new Final Assessment lab (Lab 10, Exercise 3 - Troubleshoot your Hybrid Deployment) has been added as the last activity in the course. The goal of this lab is to have the students complete a lab activity on their own without any step-by-step lab instruction. This lab builds off the prior hybrid labs the students just completed in Module 12 (Lab 10, Exercises 1 and 2). In those labs, the email being sent by

Allan Yoo to Alex Wilber is delivered to Alex's Junk Email folder rather than to his Inbox. In this final assessment lab, the students are asked to troubleshoot this problem using the information they have learned throughout the course.

A step-by-step solution guide is available for students to download if they are unable to solve the problem on their own. This solution is provided in a pdf document rather than as normal instruction in the VM environment. The student manual provides a link that students can select to download the solution guide.

IMPORTANT: Instructors should encourage students to try and solve the problem on their own first, and only download the solution guide if they are unable to do so. The whole point of this Final Assessment lab is to get students to think outside the box and use the information they have acquired in the course to solve a problem with no additional assistance. They should review the course content related to message delivery to determine what causes email messages to be interpreted as spam and delivered to recipient's Junk Email folders rather than their Inboxes. The solution guide should be used only as a last resort if students cannot figure out the solution on their own.

Final Assessment Lab Flow: The three lab exercises in Module 12 are all designed around installing a hybrid deployment in their Adatum lab environment.

- In Exercise 1, students will configure the hybrid deployment.
- In Exercise 2, students will test their newly installed hybrid deployment.
- In Exercise 3, students will perform this Final Assessment lab that asks them to troubleshoot a problem with their hybrid deployment.

The key thing for you as an instructor is to manage the flow between Exercises 2 and 3. In Exercise 2, Task 2, they will migrate an on-premises mailbox to Microsoft 365, and then in Task 3, they will test whether the migration worked. The problem is that the migration in Task 2 typically takes around an hour to complete. Instead of having students sitting around for an hour waiting for the migration to complete (especially since this is the very end of the course, which typically would be on a Friday afternoon when students are anxious to leave), students should proceed to Exercise 3 and do the Final Assessment lab while the mailbox migration is running. Exercise 3 will not affect the mailbox migration.

They key here is that once students finish with the Final Assessment lab, they should return to Exercise 2 and complete Task 3 to test the mailbox migration. They may need to wait a few minutes before starting Task 3 if they finished the Final Assessment before the hour it takes the migration to complete.

Your challenge as an instructor will be to get the students to go back and finish Task 3 once they complete the Final Assessment. Some of the students may opt to just leave once they finish the Final Assessment, but try to encourage them to stick around and perform Exercise 2, Task 3 to test their migration. Once they do, this will complete the course and they would be free to leave anyway. If they choose to leave after the Final Assessment, there's obviously nothing an instructor can do to stop them. But try and encourage them to stay and finish Task 3, which should only take them 10 to 15 minutes to complete. It would be nice if they could stick around and finish Task 3 to complete the entire course experience.

Module Review Questions

At the end of each module is a Module Review exercise that includes anywhere from 10 to 15 multiple choice questions. The answers for each question appear after the final question. If you were familiar with the online training courses that each ILT was based upon, these module review activities were actually graded exams that students took and which their final, overall course grade was largely based upon. When we transitioned to ILT classes, we decided to keep the module exams as a learning resource for the students. However, since we do not have the exam engine that was used in the online training courses to grade each student's responses, we simply display the answers at the end of each exam.

If you have time in class, you can choose to do this as a class activity; however, since the answers are available to the students, that might not prove to be very productive.

It is suggested that you have students review the questions on their own. Whether you want to set aside time in class to have students review the questions and then discuss any they may disagree with, or have them do it on their own after class as homework assignments, that is strictly up to you.

Obviously, you need to review these questions yourself prior to class so that you know why the correct answer(s) is correct for each question. Students may challenge some of the questions, so you need to be able to address any of those concerns.